

- RAG Learning

1.4 Children's Written Language Development

AQA A-Level English Language (7702) — Paper 1 Section B (3.1.3 — written modes)

Writing is a **culturally learned** system — unlike speech it requires motor skill, orthographic knowledge, awareness of genre and of a distant reader. Key frameworks: **Kroll**'s stages, **Britton**'s functions, **Rothery**'s genres, **Gentry**'s spelling stages, and **Halliday**'s metafunctions applied to text production.

1.4.1 Emergent Writing

Even before children can form letters, they produce **mark-making** — scribbles, shapes, letter-like forms. This is *emergent writing*. Key insights it displays:

- Awareness that writing uses discrete symbols arranged in lines.
- Directionality (left-to-right in English).
- Word spacing — eventually distinct "words" with gaps.
- A difference between drawing (representing things visually) and writing (representing language).

1.4.2 Kroll's Four Stages (1981)

Kroll's Four Stages of Writing Development

Preparation

up to age 6

letter formation
sound-letter links

Consolidation

around 7–8

writing = speech
"and then"

Differentiation

around 9–10

separate written
& spoken styles

Integration

teen onwards

range of styles
audience control

Preparation (up to ~6 years)

Motor control develops enough for letter formation. The child learns letter–sound correspondences, begins to use phonetic spelling, and writes primarily simple high-frequency words.

Consolidation (around 7–8 years)

Writing closely resembles the child's speech. Features: coordination with "and", "then"; simple past tense; first person; limited punctuation; expressive voice dominates. Vocabulary reflects spoken register.

Differentiation (around 9–10 years)

The child begins to distinguish between spoken and written styles. More varied sentence types, including subordination with "because", "although", "when". More formal register for appropriate genres. Punctuation becomes more consistent.

Integration (teenage years onward)

Flexible control of a range of styles adapted to audience, purpose and genre. Features: varied sentence openings, non-finite clauses, complex noun phrases, modality and evaluation, conscious register shifts, paragraphing for cohesion, skilled use of graphology.

Exam Tip: Kroll's stages are useful as a DIAGNOSTIC — "this Year 3 piece sits squarely in consolidation because...". Do not treat them as rigid. A single child may be at differentiation level for narrative but only consolidation for argument. Combine Kroll with Britton and Rothery for a richer picture.

1.4.3 Britton's Three Functions (1970)

James Britton categorised children's writing by its **function**:

Function	Description	Typical texts
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Expressive	Writing close to the self — speech on paper, personal voice, unedited.	Diaries, first drafts, letters to friends, journal entries.
Transactional	Writing that gets something done in the world — informs, persuades, reports.	Letters to institutions, reports, essays, articles.
Poetic	Crafted writing attentive to form, sound, pattern.	Poems, stories, stylised narrative.

Britton argued that early writing is predominantly expressive (children write as they speak) and gradually develops into transactional and poetic forms through schooling. A child may be at different stages across different functions.

1.4.4 Rothery's Four Genres (the Sydney School)

Joan Rothery categorised primary-school writing into genre categories, each with predictable schematic structures. Useful because it names the shapes teachers can scaffold.

Genre	Structure	Example
Recount	Orientation → events in chronological order → optional reorientation.	"At the weekend I went to..."
Report	General statement → detailed features/aspects → concluding comment.	"Penguins are birds. They live..."
Narrative	Orientation → complication → resolution (± evaluation, coda).	"One day the boy saw a dragon. But then..."
Observation / comment	Identification of an event → evaluative remark.	"We saw a robin. It was pretty."

The Sydney School argued that explicit teaching of genre is an issue of **equity**: children from homes rich in school-like literacy enter school already familiar with these structures; children without that exposure are disadvantaged unless taught them explicitly.

1.4.5 Spelling Development — Gentry's Stages

Stage	Feature	Example
Pre-communicative / pre-phonetic	Letters used but no systematic sound-letter mapping.	Random strings like "PLKMS" for "dog".
Semi-phonetic	Some sound-letter correspondences, often just consonants.	"DG" for "dog".
Phonetic	Systematic sound-by-sound spelling — not yet correct.	"cum" for "come", "nite" for "night".
Transitional	Awareness of orthographic patterns; errors reflect rules misapplied.	"beleve" (overgeneralised pattern).
Conventional	Consistent standard spelling of common words.	Correct spelling with occasional low-frequency errors.

Spelling errors in early writing are linguistic *evidence*, not just mistakes. A "phonetic" mis-spelling shows the child has internalised sound-letter mapping — a developmental milestone.

1.4.6 Grammar, Punctuation and Cohesion

Early writers typically:

- Rely on **coordination** with "and", "then", "so".
- Omit or inconsistently use **full stops**, often marking prosodic pauses with commas.
- Lack **paragraphing** and broader cohesion.
- Use simple past tense throughout narratives; tense may slip.
- Include frequent first-person perspective and evaluative comments characteristic of speech.

Development involves introducing:

- **Subordination** with "because", "although", "while", "if".
- **Non-finite clauses** ("Running down the hill, she...").
- **Complex noun phrases** with pre- and post-modification.
- **Cohesive devices** beyond temporal "then" — pronoun reference, lexical chains, connectives of contrast and causation.
- **Modality and evaluation** — "might", "should", "surprisingly".

1.4.7 Interaction with Spoken Development

Writing builds on speech but is not reducible to it. Early writing often *shows* spoken features (coordination, first-person, run-on structure). As children advance through Kroll's stages, they learn to:

- Depersonalise — third-person reports, passive constructions.
- Plan and edit — revisit and improve, unlike real-time speech.
- Address a distant reader — compensating for the absence of shared context.
- Use written-only conventions — punctuation, paragraphing, headings.

1.4.8 Scaffolding Writing — Pedagogy

Effective writing teaching draws on **Vygotsky's ZPD** and **Bruner's scaffolding**:

1. **Modelled writing** — teacher composes aloud, thinking through choices.
2. **Shared writing** — class suggests, teacher drafts.
3. **Guided writing** — small-group support on targeted skills.
4. **Independent writing** — with success criteria and self-assessment.

Genre-based pedagogy (Rothery, Sydney School) adds an explicit "teaching and learning cycle": *deconstruction* of a model text, *joint construction*, *independent construction*. This gives disadvantaged learners access to school-valued genres.

1.4.9 Digital Writing and Contemporary Considerations

Today children often begin writing digitally (messaging, social media) alongside print. Research (Crystal, Tagg, Wood) shows:

- Digital abbreviations and emoji are used with audience awareness — added registers, not deficits.
- Texters with better phonological awareness tend to produce more creative abbreviations.
- Educated children switch between digital and standard registers, suggesting integration-stage flexibility.

Prescriptivist panic about digital "ruining" children's writing is not well supported by the evidence — but equity of access and explicit teaching of standard written forms remain important.

Applied Example: A Year 6 narrative opening: *"Darkness fell across the city, silent but for a single, flickering streetlight. Mia had been waiting."* Features: post-modifying adjective phrase ("silent but for..."), complex noun phrase, past perfect progressive, short simple sentence for rhythm. Across frameworks: Kroll — integration stage (conscious style); Britton — poetic function dominant; Rothery — narrative genre; Halliday — textual metafunction strong (layered cohesion). A top-band answer names the feature, the framework, the stage and the effect on the reader.

1.4.10 How to Analyse a Child's Writing at A-Level

1. Identify **audience, purpose, genre** — what was the writing for?
2. Place the writing on **Kroll's stages** with evidence.
3. Identify **Britton's function** dominant in the piece.
4. Map the **Rothery genre structure** — is it schematically complete?
5. Analyse at linguistic levels — *lexis, grammar, graphology, cohesion*.
6. Discuss **errors as evidence** (spelling stage, virtuous errors in punctuation).
7. Integrate a **theoretical frame** — Vygotsky's ZPD for teaching implications, Halliday for metafunctions.

Exam Tip: Always link features to development. "Coordination with 'and' appears repeatedly — typical of Kroll's consolidation stage, where writing follows speech patterns. A target for this writer is varied subordination, which would move them towards differentiation." That sentence integrates feature, framework, stage and pedagogy — a top-band move.

Key Terms Checklist

Make sure you can define and give an example of: **emergent writing, mark-making, Kroll's stages (preparation / consolidation / differentiation / integration), Britton's functions (expressive / transactional / poetic), Rothery's genres (recount / report / narrative / observation-comment), Gentry's spelling stages (pre-phonetic / semi-phonetic / phonetic / transitional / conventional), orthography, coordination vs subordination, cohesion, non-finite clause, modality, scaffolding, ZPD, teaching & learning cycle.**